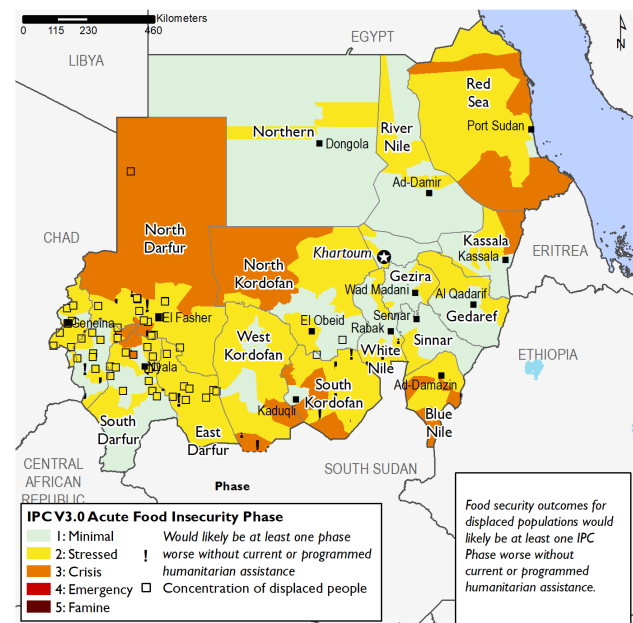


Very poor economic conditions and flooding drive high food assistance needs through May 2021

KEY MESSAGES

- Very high staple food prices from significant macroeconomic difficulties and displacement due to flooding are contributing to higher than normal emergency food assistance needs in Sudan during the ongoing 2020/21 harvest season. These needs are expected to persist into at least May 2020, particularly as the lean season approaches in agricultural and agropastoral areas. Between October 2020 and May 2021, most areas of Sudan will face Minimal (IPC Phase 1) or Stressed (IPC Phase 2) acute food insecurity, although parts of Jebel Marra, South Kordofan, Red Sea, Kassala, North Kordofan, and North Darfur will be in Crisis (IPC Phase 3).
- On October 27, Sudan's government removed all fuel subsidies, which led to an initial 400 percent increase in fuel prices, driving an over 100 percent increase in transportation costs. The prices of food and non-food items have significantly increased in response. Many of the market impacts are yet to be seen, although this is likely to drive even higher prices than previously anticipated.
- The above-normal June to September 2020 rains caused widespread flooding and delayed planting in many parts of the country. However, the above-average rainfall did drive the establishment of crops in parts of the rainfed and irrigated agricultural sectors, contributing to favorable pasture regeneration and improved water availability across main grazing areas. Currently, crops are in the vegetative, flowering, and early maturing stages. Agricultural harvests starting in late November are expected to be average at the national level, which will drive food security improvements; however, relatively notable crop losses are expected in Gadaref, Sennar, and the Blue Nile due to expected delays in harvest from flooding and the anticipated labor shortage.
- The comprehensive peace agreement recently signed between the Sudanese Government and the Sudan Revolutionary Front rebel alliance (SRF) and the ongoing peace talks with SPLM-N El Hilu are expected to facilitate gradual improvements in security, promote the voluntary return of IDPs, improve trade flows, and increased humanitarian access to most conflict-affected areas in South Kordofan and Darfur. Given the gradual nature of these likely changes, though, no major change in the security situation and access is expected during the outlook period due to the anticipated limited impact of the peace arrangement on the macroeconomic crisis and staple food prices.

Current food security outcomes, October 2020



Source: FEWS NET

FEWS NET classification is IPC-compatible. IPC-compatible analysis follows key IPC protocols but does not necessarily reflect the consensus of national food security partners.

NATIONAL OVERVIEW

Current Situation

An atypical high number of people will require emergency food assistance in Sudan throughout the scenario period. Poor macroeconomic conditions, very high staple food prices, and the loss of assets from the worst flooding the country has seen in 30 years will limit household food access despite the upcoming average harvest. The worst-affected areas will be in Crisis (IPC Phase 3), including parts of Jebel Marra and South Kordofan, Red Sea and Kassala states. An increasing number of the households in western Sudan and urban centers, including Khartoum, will face increased difficulty meeting their food needs due to reduced purchasing power-driven by the loss of assets in flooding, poor macroeconomic conditions, and very high staple food prices and are expected to be in Crisis (IPC Phase 3).

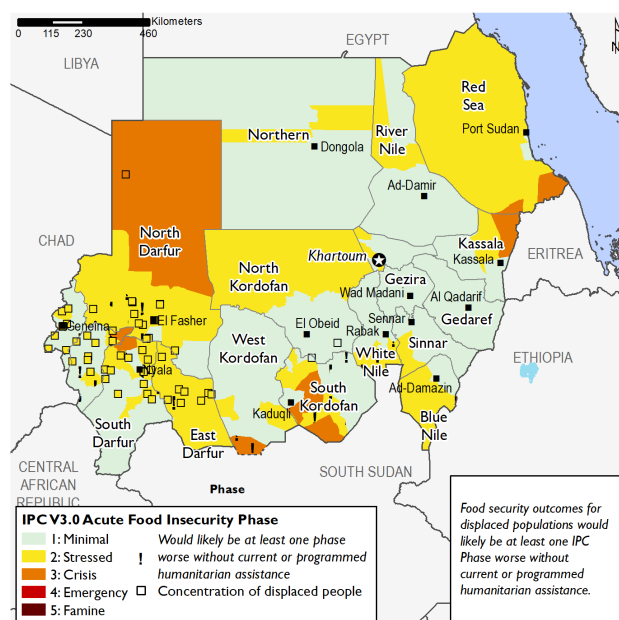
Macroeconomic crisis

Sudan continues to face a deteriorating macroeconomic situation that has been exacerbated by COVID-19 restrictions and flooding. In September 2020, the government declared a State of Economic Emergency and announced the formation of a joint mechanism to protect the Sudanese economy. However, Sudan continues to face severely limited foreign currency reserves in the official banking system and reduced access to sufficient foreign exchange resources due to structural economic factors and export losses from smuggling and speculation. The Sudanese Pound value continues to weaken in the parallel market, depreciating from 170 SDG/USD in August to 240 SDG/USD by mid-October 2020. According to the Central Bureau of Statistics (CBS), the national inflation rate increased by around 45 percent from approximately 167 percent in August 2020 to 212 percent in September 2020. The macroeconomic crisis is continuing to negatively impact households' purchasing power, particularly poor households in flood-affected areas. The macroeconomic crisis is exacerbated by a significant increase in the need to import essential food and non-food items (agricultural inputs, health and medical equipment, etc.) to mitigate the loss of assets and infrastructure from flooding and meet emergency health care and COVID-19 pandemic needs.

On October 27, 2020, Sudan's government removed all fuel subsidies, leading to a 400 percent increase in fuel prices. On October 28, a liter of gasoline will be sold at 120 SDG instead of 28 SDG previously. The price of a liter of diesel increased from 23 SDG/liter to 106 SDG/liter, and the in petrol increased from 28 SDG/liter to 120SDG/liter. The rise in fuel prices has led to a more than 100 percent increase in Khartoum transportation tariffs and is expected to lead to a steep increase in food and non-food items.

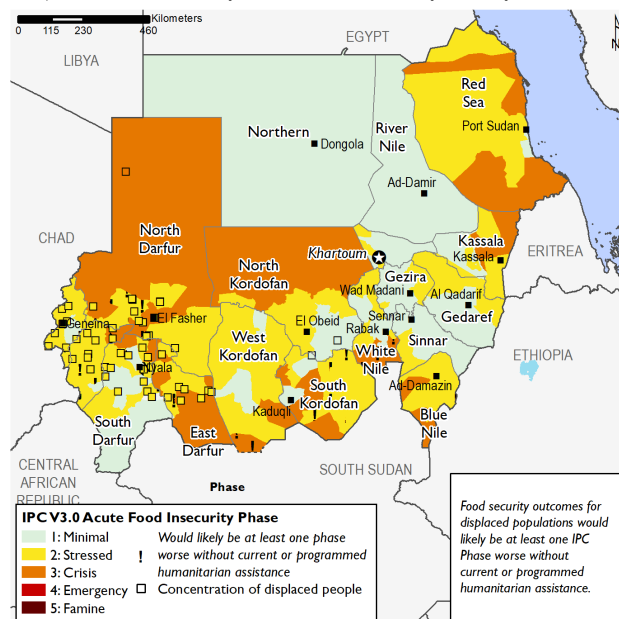
In October, Sudan continues facing severe wheat and wheat flour shortages due to the Sudanese Pound's FOREX shortage and rapid devaluation. According to the Strategic Reserve Corporation, Sudan needs over 1 million MT of wheat to cover

Projected food security outcomes, October 2020 to January 2021



Source: FEWS NET

Projected food security outcomes, February to May 2021



Source: FEWS NET

FEWS NET classification is IPC-compatible. IPC-compatible analysis follows key IPC protocols but does not necessarily reflect the consensus of national food security partners.

consumption needs through March-April 2021, the next local wheat harvest. The United Arab Emirates (UAE) and WFP are expected to initially provide around 430,000 MT and 80,000 MT of wheat, respectively, as part of a broader commitment by the UAE and WFP to provide 200,000 MT and 450,000 MT, respectively. Sudan is expected to import over 400,000 MT to cover the anticipated wheat deficit through April 2021.

Prices and term-of-trade

Retail prices of sorghum and millet (the main staples) had mixed trends between September, the peak of the lean season, and the pre-harvest period of October 2020. Across most major monitored markets, prices increased by 5-15 percent. Still, there were reported 40-50 percent price increases in Om Dorman (the primary consumption market in Khartoum) and Kadugli markets due to relatively high demand and transportation costs. However, retail sorghum and millet prices decreased by 5-10 percent in Geneina and Kosti markets and the main market of El Obeid due to the increased supply from last year's carry-over stock. On average, sorghum sold for 75 SDG/kg in October compared to 70 SDG/kg in September. The mixed trends in prices were attributed to the availability of early maturing crops seasonally decreasing prices, the high cost of production and transportation, and the rapid depreciation of the Sudanese Pound, which kept prices high or increasing. In October, across main markets, sorghum and millet prices are 200-300 percent above respective prices last year and five to six times the recent five-year average for September. Border closures and high sorghum prices in Sudan have significantly reduced formal and informal cross-border sorghum exports. The July-September 2020 informal cross-border exports of sorghum, primarily to Eritrea, were estimated at just 352 MT compared to approximately 3,350 MT to Ethiopia and Eritrea in 2019.

The retail price for locally produced wheat increased seasonally by 10-20 percent in most main wheat production and consumption markets across the country between September and October 2020, with 50 percent price increases in Khartoum and Madani's main consumption markets. In Khartoum, the largest wheat consumption market in Sudan, locally produced wheat sold for 92.5 SDG/kg in October compared to 60 SDG/kg in September 2020. In October, the national wheat price is, on average, 150 percent above respective prices last year and 400 percent above the five-year average. Seasonally tightened supplies drive the high prices on top of current national shortages, high transportation costs, and high demand driven by the lean season and flood damage to household food stocks.

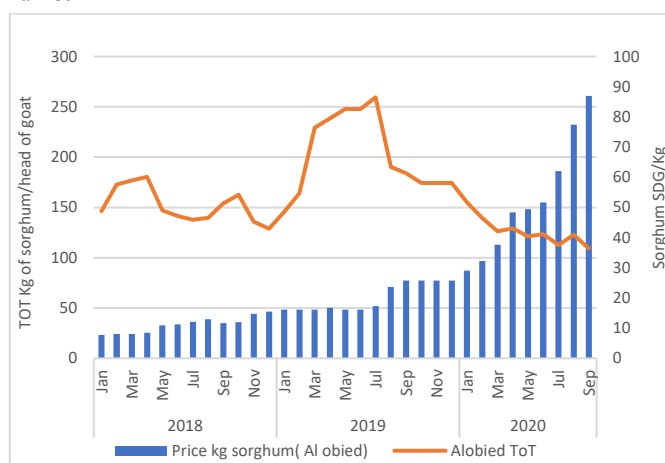
Goat and sheep prices either remained stable or decreased 5-10 percent across most markets between September and October 2020 due to increased market supplies as export demand, particularly from Saudi Arabia, remains low. However, livestock prices remained 90-100 percent above last year and 200-300 percent above the five-year average. The high prices are mainly attributed to the rapid depreciation of the Sudanese Pound, the continued deterioration of the macroeconomic situation, and the high transportation costs between areas of production and main markets.

Livestock-to-cereal terms-of-trade (TOT) remained lower than last year and the five-year average, as food prices continue to increase at greater rates than livestock prices. In September, the goats-to-sorghum TOT dropped by 11 and 14 percent compared to August in the El Obied market and Zalengi market, respectively. In El Obied, the goats-to-sorghum TOT fell from August to September from around 123 kg/head to 109 kg/head (Figure 1). However, in Zalengi, prices fell from around 76kg/head to 66kg/head from August to September, driven primarily by stable goat prices and a 10-20 percent increase in September sorghum prices. In September 2020, the national goat-to-sorghum TOT was 15-40 percent lower than September 2019 and 40-70 percent lower than the five-year average.

Seasonal Performance

June to September 2020, rainfall performance was above average across most of Sudan. Average rain in July and above-average rainfall in August and September caused flash floods and waterlogging across most of the country, with Khartoum, Sennar, Northern, River Nile, and North Darfur the most affected states. Torrential rainfall and overflow of the River Nile and its tributaries during August and September resulted in

Figure 1. Goats-to-sorghum terms-of-trade (kg/head), El Obeid market



Source: FEWS NET

the worst flooding in decades, affecting almost all 18 states of Sudan. According to the Humanitarian Aid Commission (HAC) and OCHA, as of mid-September 2020, the flooding had killed about 155 people and directly affected over 875,000 people through the destruction or damage of over 175,000 houses, submerging around 1,400,000 hectares of cropped land and killing over 35,000 head of livestock. In mid-October, the Normalized Difference Vegetation Index (NDVI) showed dense vegetation conditions (over 140 percent of median) across central, western, and southeastern Sudan. NDVI also remains above the median across most parts of Northern and River Nile state, northern Red Sea state, and southern parts of South Kordofan and South Darfur states (Figure 2).

Cropping and Vegetation Conditions

According to the recently conducted mid-season assessment, the total area planted for sorghum, millet, groundnuts, sesame, and cotton by the end of August was around 54 million feddans (22.7 million hectares), approximately 86 percent of the targeted area. As planting of some crops continued during the assessment, mainly in the semi-mechanized and irrigated sectors, the planted area is expected to increase to around 61 million feddans (25.6 million hectares) by the end of September, approximately 95 percent of the targeted area. By mid-September, an estimated 96 percent of the 2020/21 planned sorghum crop was planted across 25.4 million feddans (10.7 million hectares). Additionally, around 1 million feddans (420,000 ha) of sorghum were planted through September to replace sesame impacted by waterlogging and sesame gall midge infestations.

Field reports indicate a good establishment of crops in both the rainfed and irrigated sectors, with most crops between the flowering and filling stages. Most of the sesame and groundnuts are at the filling and early maturing stage and expected to be harvested in November while late-planted sorghum and millet, particularly in areas affected by flooding, particularly Gedarif, Blue Nile, Sennar, and East Darfur states, are at the advanced vegetative growth stage and expected to be harvested in December and January.

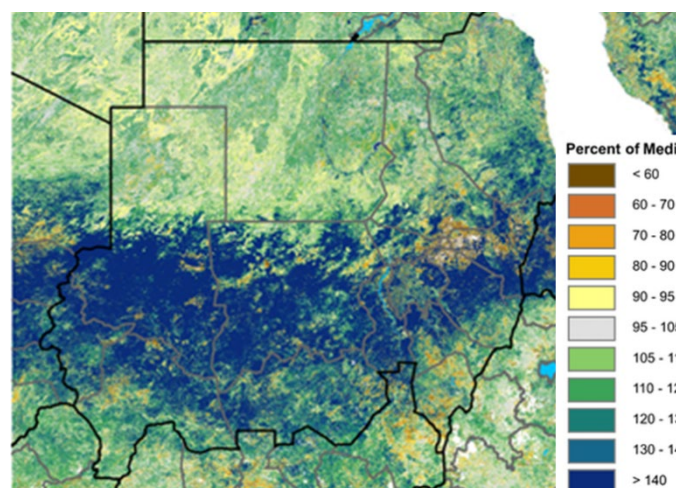
Desert Locusts:

According to the [October 2020 Desert Locust Bulletin](#), mature solitary adults and groups of desert locusts were observed on the Red Sea coast north of Toker Delta in September. However, more immature and mature adults and swarms were observed from northern Haiya to South of Dordaib in Red Sea state where egg-laying has occurred, and hatching and band formation has commenced. Scattered immature and mature solitary adults were present in North Darfur, near El Fasher and North Kordofan near Sodari, the River Nile between Shandi and Atbara, and along the Atbara river. The infestation of desert locusts between October and December in these areas will remain a potential threat to summer season crops during the harvest period and the winter season crops during germination and early growth stages.

Livestock

The above-normal rains have driven favorable pasture regeneration and improved water availability for livestock across most pastoral and agropastoral areas. As of mid-October 2020, vegetation conditions as inferred by NDVI remain above 140 percent of normal across much of the main grazing areas in eastern and western parts of the country, including most of Darfur and North Kordofan states and parts of Gadaref, Sennar, and Kassala states. According to the [USGS water point viewer](#), there are good water conditions across most monitoring points. However, in August, heavy rains resulted in increased flooding and waterlogging, which led to average to below-average pasture conditions in parts of Blue Nile, South Kordofan and Kassala, and Darfur states. Destruction of some open water sources (Bout dam) by the flooding is expected to result in water shortages during the post-harvest (December/January) livestock migration to summer season grazing areas in parts of Kordofan and Blue Nile state

Figure 2: Normalized Difference Vegetation Index (NDVI), percent of median, October 11 - 20, 2020



Source: FEWS NET/USGS

Improved livestock body conditions and production are being driven by the above normal vegetation and improved pasture and water access in most pastoral and agropastoral livelihood zones in western, central, and eastern Sudan. Near normal

seasonal movements of transhumant pastoralists into wet season grazing areas in the northern parts of the country have been reported along most traditional animal migratory routes.

COVID-19 related information

By October 22, 2020, the number of officially confirmed cumulative COVID-19 cases was 13,724. However, the number of daily cases continues to decline. In mid-October, the bi-weekly number of newly confirmed cases was approximately 51 compared to 105 cases during the last week of September. The rate of positive cases from tested samples has also declined from 1 percent to 0.4 percent; however, testing remains limited and primarily undertaken for certified travelers departing the country. Over 80 percent of cases in October have been reported in Khartoum state.

As of October 2020, Sudan has eased most COVID-19 control measures, including opening all economic activities and interstate travels, reopening airports for international travel, and allowing free movements of goods through seaports and land crossings. On October 17, all border crossings between Sudan and Ethiopia were officially reopened for trade, while population movements across most borders remain controlled. Nevertheless, field informants reported active informal cross border labor movement from Ethiopia towards agricultural schemes to join the harvesting season. The improved cross-border labor movement will likely improve the availability of harvest labor in the semi-mechanized agricultural areas. Still, available labor is likely to remain below average due to labor shortages and high transportation costs, high cost of leaving, and below the average rate of cross-border labor movements from Ethiopia.

Income

Opportunities and wages for agricultural labor have significantly increased in September and October due to continued replanting and weeding activities caused by flooding and waterlogging in earlier harvested cash crops. Agricultural labor wages increased by 20-30 percent between June and October 2020. Wages were 400-600 SDG/day in October 2020 compared to 250-350 SDG/day for the same period last year, a 60-70 percent increase, while remaining 230 percent above the five-year average. Despite the increase in wage rates, the labor-to-sorghum TOT dropped 24 percent between June to October 2020 as sorghum prices increased by 40-60 percent compared to the 20-30 increase in labor wages.

The easing of COVID-19 related restrictions over the past few months has likely improved rural poor household access to non-agricultural income to near-normal levels, particularly income from remittances sent by household members working in traditional gold mining, migrant labor, and domestic labor main towns, along with income from the collection and sale of forest products. In urban centers, following the easing of COVID-19 restrictions, poor households are dependent on petty trade and daily labor opportunities at markets and industrial areas, domestic work, and migrant labor.

Conflict and Displacement

On October 3, 2020, after a year of intensive negotiations, the Sudanese government and the Sudan Revolutionary Front rebel alliance (SRF) signed a [comprehensive peace agreement](#). The agreement includes eight protocols for Darfur, South Kordofan, Blue Nile, and central, eastern, and northern Sudan. A federal regional system of government will be re-established, and the signatories will be represented in the Sovereign Council, Ministerial council of the transitional government, and the Transitional Legislative Council. The agreement is expected to slowly improve humanitarian access and improve trade flows, food prices, and food availability to former SRF-held areas.

Despite the recent signing of the peace agreement, sporadic tribal clashes and civil unrest continued in some parts of western and eastern Sudan. However, limited new internal displacement has been reported since January 2020. The number of internally displaced people (IDPs) in Sudan has remained at around 1.8 million, located mostly in Darfur, South Kordofan, and Blue Nile states. In late September, there were approximately 729,500 refugees from neighboring countries, primarily South Sudan.

Humanitarian Assistance

In September 2020, WFP and implementing partners provided approximately 2,725,159 million beneficiaries with 16,144 MT in-kind assistance of food commodities and 829,882 USD in cash vouchers, representing 55 percent of the planned quantity and 109 percent of the planned cash voucher equivalent value, respectively. Most beneficiaries reached by humanitarian assistance were IDPs and conflict-affected people in Greater Darfur, government-controlled areas of South Kordofan and Blue

Nile, refugees from South Sudan, and flood-affected people in addition to chronically food-insecure areas of eastern and western Sudan. WFP is planning to distribute a total of 78,852 MT of food commodities and 10 million USD in cash vouchers to over 2.6 million beneficiaries between October and December 2020.

Summary of Food Security Outcomes

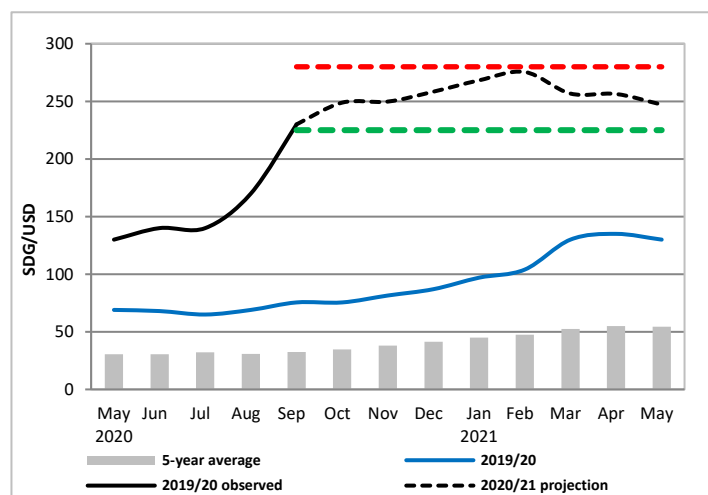
In October, household food security has begun to improve seasonally, driven by the increased availability of own production of earlier maturing crops from the ongoing 2020/21 agricultural season, in-kind and cash payments from agricultural labor, and improved income from the sale of early maturing crops, allowing market purchases. However, the persistent macroeconomic difficulties and continued above-average prices of essential food and non-food items exacerbated by the widespread flooding are driving worse food security outcomes than are typical during the harvest period. Moreover, the high need for reconstruction from flood damage combined with extremely high prices of construction materials, and food production and transportation costs, has significantly limited poor households' ability to maintain their typical access to food and income. These challenges are driving Stressed (IPC Phase 2) outcomes across many areas of the country, while Crisis (IPC Phase 3) outcomes exist in conflict-affected areas and areas hosting IDPs in Jebel Marra; SPLM-N controlled areas of South Kordofan; in addition to the northern parts of north Darfur, parts of North Kordofan, northern Kassala, and Red Sea states.

Assumptions

The most likely scenario for June 2020 to January 2021 is based on the following national-level assumptions:

- The total number of cases of COVID-19 is expected to increase during the projection period. Compliance with control measures is expected to remain generally low across the country.
- COVID-19 prevention and control measures are expected to remain at minimum levels throughout the scenario period. Monitoring and controlling people and goods through airports, seaports, and land crossings is expected to continue. Social distancing control measures such as restricting big gatherings are expected to remain in place. They are anticipated to have minimal effects on food and income sources during the outlook period.
- Sudan is likely to continue facing severe macroeconomic difficulties associated with low foreign exchange reserves in the official banking system and the informal market through May 2021. Shortages of foreign currency are likely to continue and will be exacerbated by increased demand for imports of essential food and non-food items. However, some additional income from the export of oil crops, animals, and animal products is expected during the post-harvest period of January to April 2021.
- Based on FEWS NET's integrated projections, the SDG is likely to depreciate further on the parallel market and be between 225 and 280 SDG/USD during the scenario period (Figure 3).
- Based on FEWS NET's integrated price projections, retail prices for sorghum and millet are expected to seasonally begin gradually decreasing in October 2020 with the beginning of the harvest period of the ongoing 2020/21 main agricultural season through March 2021. Overall, sorghum and millet prices are expected to be over 200 percent higher than last year and 400-600 percent above the five-year average during the scenario period. Prices for locally produced wheat are expected to continue to increase or remain stable between October 2020 and February 2021. In March 2021, wheat prices are anticipated to decrease seasonally with the beginning of the winter season harvest but will remain over 150 percent higher than October 2019 prices and more than 300-400 percent above the five-year average.

Figure 3. Integrated FEWS NET exchange rate projection (SDG/USD) on the parallel and official markets



Source: FEWS NET

- Sudan is expected to import around 2 million MT of wheat between October 2020 and May 2021, compared to 2.5 million MT for the same period last year and 1.8 million MT for the five-year average. Also, Sudan is expected to import 60,000 MT of rice and 23,000 MT of maize. Levels of imports will remain below average because of the growing shortage of foreign exchange.
- Shortages and high prices of fuel (diesel) are expected to persist across Sudan through May 2021. Fuel prices in remote areas of Darfur, South Kordofan, and Northern states will remain around more than double the prices in central Sudan, while fuel prices on the informal market will likely be more than six times as high as official prices across the country.
- Remittances by migrant family members in areas of seasonal labor migration and traditional gold mining in Sudan and remittances by family members abroad represent a significant income source for poor and middle groups in most livelihood zones of Sudan. Remittance levels are likely to improve compared to the last six months due to improvements in household members' access to labor opportunities in areas abroad due to the partial lifting of COVID-19-related restrictions on population movements and border closures curfews, and the repatriation of Sudanese from some countries.
- Livestock prices are expected to remain relatively stable or increase by 5-10 percent in most markets during the harvest and post-harvest period (October 2020 through March 2021) due to improved animal body conditions from favorable pasture conditions and an expected decline of cereal prices during the post-harvest period. Livestock prices are likely to start seasonally decreasing by the beginning of the lean season (April/May 2021) as households sell additional livestock to fund staple food purchases and build household food stocks. Overall, livestock prices are expected to remain almost double compared to last year and 300-400 percent above the five-year average.
- Based on projected cereal and goat prices, goat-to-cereal terms-of-trade are expected to decline 5 to 10 percent between October 2020 and May 2021 and remain on average 15 percent lower than last year and 30 percent below the five-year average throughout the scenario period mainly due to the high increase in the price of sorghum relative to the price of a goat.
- The destruction and damage from heavy rains and floods to homes and infrastructure and the high loss of household assets and cropped areas are expected to compromise the expected harvest and weaken poor households' capacity to meet their essential food and livelihood needs. Stagnant water and poor sanitation and hygiene in most affected areas will increase household vulnerability to waterborne diseases.
- The above-average rainfall of the ongoing 2020/21 agricultural season is likely to support favorable crop yields in both rainfed and irrigated agricultural areas of Sudan. However, portions of cropped areas in some of the rain-fed semi-mechanized and irrigated agricultural sectors have been impacted by flooding and waterlogging, particularly cash crops. This is likely to compromise the forecasted above-average harvest, particularly for sesame and cotton.
- According to the October 2020 Desert Locust Bulletin, hatching and band formation are likely to occur in eastern Sudan between Kassala and Haiya until mid-October, with fledging and the formation of immature swarms from early November onwards. In the summer breeding areas, a few small groups may form west of the Nile Valley as vegetation dries out. In the winter breeding areas, breeding is expected to start on the Red Sea coast from October onwards and may be supplemented by groups and small swarms from Eritrea.
- Agricultural labor opportunities and wages are expected to increase from 450-550 SDG per day to 700-800 SDG in the semi-mechanized sector and 500-600 per day for the traditional sector during the harvesting period (December-February). Labor wages are anticipated to be 70-100 percent above last year and 200-300 percent above the five-year average due to an expected labor shortage due to the current border closures. Laborers are expected to demand higher wages in response to continued local currency depreciation and rising prices of other goods and services. The labor-to-sorghum terms of trade are expected to be 250-300 percent lower than last year and 100-150 percent lower than the five-year average.
- The recently initialed comprehensive peace agreement between the Sudanese government and the Sudan Revolutionary Front rebel alliance is expected to reduce conflict and contribute to stability in the conflict-affected zones of Darfur, South Kordofan, and Blue Nile as well as reducing tribal clashes in eastern Sudan and increase the voluntary return of IDPs throughout the outlook period. However, sporadic tribal clashes are expected in some parts of western and eastern Sudan. Low levels of new internal displacement are expected. Overall, the number of IDPs

in Sudan is expected to remain around 1.5 million, mostly in Darfur, South Kordofan, and Blue Nile states. The number of refugees from neighboring countries, primarily South Sudan, is expected to remain near one million through the outlook period.

- WFP and implementing partners are likely to provide emergency food assistance to over four million beneficiaries, including IDPs and conflict-affected people in Darfur, Kordofan and Blue Nile, and refugees from South Sudan. A scaleup in assistance to an additional 2.2 million people is possible under plans to reach households affected by COVID-19 measures. Although no regular humanitarian access to SPLM-N-controlled areas of South Kordofan and parts of Jebel Mara and Blue Nile is assumed for this scenario period, ongoing peace talks and efforts by the government and SPLM-N could lead to increased access and assistance in these areas.
- The above-average June to September 2020 rains has generated good pasture conditions in main grazing areas and improved livestock access to water, improving livestock body conditions. However, the reported wide expansion of cultivated areas into grazing lands in western and central Sudan, the closure of some main animal seasonal migratory routes, and flooding are expected to delay livestock movements to summer season grazing areas in the southern part of the country. This is likely to increase conflict between nomads and farmers in areas where late cultivation/replanting occurred, and animal graze before the harvest.

Most Likely Food Security Outcomes

Between October 2020 to January 2021, the main harvest season is expected to significantly improve access to food and income from own production, in-kind payments for agricultural labor, and in-kind support from relatives compared to the lean season (June to September). Likewise, income from agricultural labor and cash crops' sale will support market purchases of food when staple food prices typically decrease. Despite the expected improvements in household food access, overall food security outcomes are expected to remain worse than is typical driven by significantly above-average food prices, reduced household purchasing power, and high food and reconstruction needs impacted by the recent flooding. Nevertheless, food security outcomes for many areas will improve to Minimal (IPC Phase 1) and Stressed (IPC Phase 2). However, Crisis (IPC Phase 3) outcome are likely among IDPs in SPLM-N controlled areas of South Kordofan, IDPs and conflict-affected households in Jebel Marra in Darfur, and among poor households in parts of North Darfur, North Kordofan, Red Sea, and Kassala states, as the high staple food prices and lower than normal purchasing power drive higher than usual food assistance needs.

February to May 2021 marks the post-harvest period and the beginning of the lean season. During the post-harvest period, food security outcomes typically stabilize but will begin to deteriorate in April as household food stocks begin to diminish. In-kind payments from agricultural labor, cash crops, and livestock are also typically at seasonal lows from February through May. More households will increase their dependency on market food purchases as staple food prices begin to increase seasonally. The anticipated above-average prices of food and non-food items, along with low household purchasing power-driven by the persistent macroeconomic difficulties and impact of the flooding on harvest and infrastructure, will continue to drive higher needs than in a typical year. IDPs and poor households in conflict-affected areas in parts of Jebel Marra of Darfur and SPLM-N area of South Kordofan, and increased numbers of poor households in parts of North Darfur, northern Kassala, and much of Red Sea states will begin to face food consumption gaps by April and likely be in Crisis (IPC Phase 3). Many areas in North Darfur and parts of North Kordofan, southern Blue Nile, northern Kassala, and the Red Sea will likely remain Stressed (IPC Phase 2) between February and May 2021.

Events that Might Change the Outlook

Possible events over the next eight months that could change the most-likely scenario.

Area	Event	Impact on food security outcomes
National	A significant increase in COVID-19 cases leading to the reinstatement of COVID-19 control measures including lockdown, and the closure of borders and land crossings.	This would disrupt typical income-earning opportunities for some populations, contributing to further deterioration of the macroeconomic situation and will affect access to food and income for most households. This is likely to increase the number of people in need and facing Crisis (IPC Phase 3) and worse outcomes.
National	Reintegration into the international economy; increased support from the international community; or significant improvements in macroeconomic conditions.	Improved macroeconomic conditions would improve availability, reduce the prices of essential food and non-food items, and improve household purchasing power. This is likely to reduce the number of people facing Stressed (IPC Phase 2) and Crisis (IPC Phase 3) acute food insecurity outcomes.

AREAS OF CONCERN

Sudan People Liberation Movement-North (SPLM-N) controlled areas of South Kordofan state (Figure 5)

Current Situation

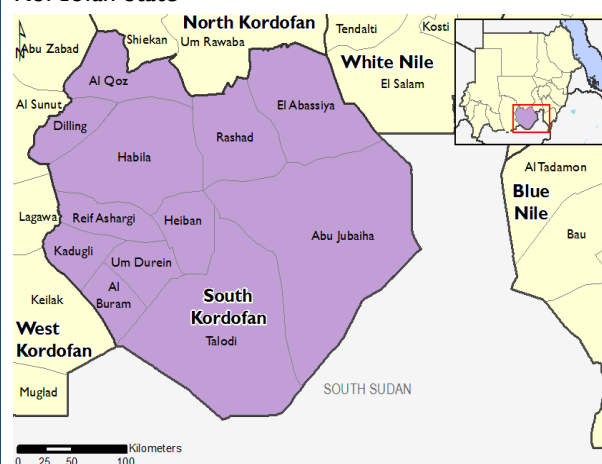
This area of concern includes areas in South Kordofan state controlled by the Sudan People's Liberation Movement-North under the leadership of Abdelaziz El Hilu (SPLM-N El Hilu). Since the beginning of the conflict in 2011 through 2018/2019, high numbers of IDPs and conflict-affected people have fled to Kawuda, Haiban Al Buram, and Umdurain localities in SPLM-N controlled areas at different periods. IDPs and conflict-affected people in these areas have limited access to their normal livelihood sources and inadequate humanitarian assistance access.

On October 18, 2020, the Sudanese transitional government and the SPLM-N El Hilu signed an agreement to resume peace talks and develop a roadmap for South Kordofan peace negotiations. However, SPLM-N El Hilu is one of two rebel groups that did not sign the recent comprehensive peace agreement between the Sudanese government and the Sudan Revolutionary Front rebel alliance on October 3, 2020, in the South Sudanese capital of Juba.

Despite improved access to rebel-controlled areas since the removal of the previous regime in Sudan in early 2019, population movement and trade flows into the area continue to be constrained by extremely high transportation costs due to poor road conditions and severe fuel shortages. The cost of transportation into SPLM-N El Hilu areas is close to double the price compared to government control areas of South Kordofan and about three-times above transportation cost in other parts of the country.

Across most parts of SPLM-N El Hilu areas of South Kordofan, the start of the rainfall in late July was erratic and generally below the seasonal mean resulting in below normal NDVI values. However, the rains started to improve by August as near average rainfall in August through September improved vegetation conditions and a return to average NDVI conditions by

Figure 5. Area of concern reference map, South Kordofan State



Source: FEWS NET

the end of September. Due to the delayed rains, delayed planting in late July was reported across most areas. Available field information suggests that most IDPs and conflict-affected households planted farms near their residential areas or home gardens (Jubraka). According to the July 2020 FSMU report, about 48 percent of interviewed households reported planting less than normal due to the delayed start of the rains, shortage of agricultural inputs, and insecurity.

In SPLM-N areas, sorghum prices followed seasonal trends but were higher than government-controlled areas. Between June and July 2020, sorghum prices increased by 20-45 percent in most markets in the area and up to 70 percent in some individual markets but remained, on average, almost twice the price of the government-controlled regions. In July 2020, sorghum sold at 75-130 SDG/Kg compared to 50-100 SDG/Kg in June across most markets in the area. In July, the price of sorghum remained 85-160 percent above respective 2019 prices and more than two times higher than the five-year average. High prices in the SPLM-N areas were related to reduced market supplies due to the relatively below-average harvest of last year, seasonally high demand, and high transportation costs.

In SPLM-N areas, livestock prices increased slightly or remained relatively stable between June and July in most monitored markets due to improvements in animal body conditions and improved access to markets. Livestock prices in local markets increased by 20-25 percent in July 2020 and remained similar to last year.

Non-cereal food items, such as sugar, salt, and beans, increased by 15-20 percent between June and July 2020 and remained above average across most markets in the area. Non-food items prices such as soap and fuel increased by 30-40 percent in July and remained significantly above (150-250 percent) the five-year average. Generally, prices of food and non-food items in SPLM-N areas are almost double compared to respective prices in government-controlled areas.

According to WFP September food distribution figures, about 13,616 people in SPLM-N areas received humanitarian food assistance. In government-controlled areas of South Kordofan, 54,890 IDPs, 15,819 refugees, and 2,565 residents received humanitarian food assistance. WFP is expected to maintain at least the same level of humanitarian assistance through December 2020.

Assumptions

- Ongoing peace talks are likely to result in relative stability in the overall security situation from October 2020 to January 2021. Still, there is uncertainty and a risk for a return to insecurity during the peace talk period. Access to SPLM-N controlled areas by humanitarian assistance and free trade flows is expected to improve during the scenario period and likely improve household availability and food access.
- Household food access is expected to improve, particularly during the harvest period, with the expected availability of own household production, in-kind payment, and a reduction in cereal prices. However, household food access will seasonally deteriorate from March through the beginning of the lean season in May 2021, when the depletion of household food stocks and reduced availability of wild food is expected.
- Cereal prices are expected to seasonally decline with the start of the harvest in October 2020 through January 2021 and begin atypically increasing from March through May 2021. In March to May 2021, prices are expected to remain approximately more than double compared to respective 2020 prices and about three-times the five-year average. The main drivers of the price increases through the scenario period is the expected low-level production, high transportation costs, and the overall high prices in neighboring production markets in government areas.

Most Likely Food Security Outcomes

From October 2020 to January 2021, most IDP households' food access is expected to improve relative to previous conflict years. Households will depend on their own household's production, in-kind payments, wild foods, market purchases, and relatives' support. However, this improvement will remain below average due to low production levels and above-average staple food prices. Additionally, chronic low access to income and limited purchasing power for IDP households will continue to limit their ability to expand market purchases to meet basic food requirements. Therefore, the majority of IDP households in the area are likely to continue facing moderate food consumption gaps from October 2020 to January 2021 and likely face Crisis (IPC Phase 3) outcomes due to inadequate humanitarian assistance.

February to May 2021 covers the post-harvest period through the beginning of the lean season. It is expected that most IDP households will increase their dependency on market purchases as their main source of food by March 2021, when cereal prices typically begin to increase seasonally and household food stocks diminish. With the beginning of the lean season in

April, household stocks of cereal and wild foods will be depleted as cereal prices typically peak. Household purchasing power will be limited by reduced agricultural labor opportunities and wages and the expected above-average price of cereal and non-cereal food items. As IDPs generally face extremely low-income levels, from February to May 2021, IDP household access to adequate basic food items will further deteriorate, and food consumption deficits are likely to widen. The number of households expected to face Crisis (IPC Phase 3) from February to May 2021 is expected to increase. While the area will remain in Crisis (IPC Phase 3) through the scenario period, food security outcomes for the worst-affected households will deteriorate to Emergency (IPC Phase 4) in the absence of humanitarian assistance.

Events that Might Change the Outlook

Possible events over the next eight months that could change the most-likely scenario.

Area	Event	Impact on food security outcomes
(SPLM-N El Hilu) controlled areas of South Kordofan state.	Failure of peace talks	Failure of the peace talks between the SPLM-N El Hilu and the government will delay peace arrangements. If the negotiations fail, access to free trade and the return of IDPs to their home villages will be impacted. Access to farming, basic livelihoods, and humanitarian assistance will also be limited, worsening household access to food. The area classification will likely deteriorate from Crisis (IPC Phase 3) to Emergency (IPC Phase 4) during April and May 2021 in such a scenario due to conflict and movement restrictions.

Tokar, Agig, and Haya localities of the Red Sea state affected by flooding (Figure 6)

Current Situation

By mid-September 2020, heavy rains, and flooding of the Khor Baraka seasonal river in Red Sea state, resulted in the widespread destruction of houses, infrastructure, the loss of assets and food stocks, and displacement. The most affected localities are Tokar, Haya, and Agig. According to the Humanitarian Aid Commission (HAC) and field reports, an estimated 50,700 individuals (10,140 households) have been directly affected by the flooding. Approximately 10,140 houses were damaged or destroyed, 400 head of livestock have been killed, and about 27,635 sacks of 90kg bags of food stocks were lost, along with the submersion of large areas of cropped land. The 1,973 households who lost their homes to flooding have been displaced but are staying with relatives in Port Sudan and other towns. The flooding also damaged key basic infrastructure in the area, including health facilities, schools, and markets, and destroyed the main road between Tokar and Port Sudan.

Figure 6. Area of concern reference map, Red Sea State



Source: FEWS NET

According to field reports, most affected localities did not start planting on time this year due to waterlogging impacting large cropland areas. Additionally, the flooding also cut-off access to main roads to the area for almost one month, negatively impacting the supply of food and non-food items from the main production markets of Gadaref and Sennar. The lack of road access and the macroeconomic crisis increased transportation costs in August and September to five times the price compared to 2019.

Staple food prices in Red Sea state have continued to increase through 2020. In September, cereal prices in the Port Sudan market increased by 15 percent compared to July 2020 and remained 270 percent above respective prices last year and 770 percent above the five-year average. In September 2020, sorghum prices in Agig and Tokar local markets were 33 and 18 percent higher than in Port Sudan. Cereal supplies into local markets of focus areas have significantly declined with the lean season's progression from May to September, exacerbated by inaccessibility due to flooded roads and the high transportation

cost. Most poor households in the affected area have lost their food stocks and are entirely dependent on market purchases and relatives' support. This has reduced the ability of poor households to obtain adequate food from markets.

Livestock prices have also increased throughout the year, driven by the macroeconomic crisis, depreciation of the Sudanese Pound, the high cost of breeding, and high transportation costs. In September, sheep prices in the Port Sudan market increased by 17 percent compared to July 2020 and remained 100 percent above respective prices last year and 350 percent above the five-year average.

In Red Sea state, the inflation rate has steadily increased from approximately 98 percent in June to 110 percent in July and then 135 percent in August 2020, a nearly 38 percent increase over two months. The rise in inflation helps drive sharp increases in food and drink prices, further weakening households' access to food from markets.

Impacted by multiple shocks including the macroeconomic crisis, depreciation of the Sudanese Pound, loss of food and livelihood assets from flooding, high transportation costs, and an extended lean season due to delayed planting, poor households in SPLM-N controlled areas are unable to meet their minimum food needs and are likely facing food consumption gaps leading to Crisis (IPC Phase 3) outcomes.

Assumptions

- The delay in cultivation due to flooding is likely to reduce the area cultivated and delay the typical start of harvest in December 2020. These areas are likely to begin experiencing improvements in availability and access to own production and market supplies by early 2021.
- Displacement due to flooding is likely to reduce agricultural labor availability. Many households who lost their houses might not return for cultivation, likely influencing planting and weeding activities from October to December. The cost of labor is expected to be more than double compared to the last season.
- Desert locusts will remain a potential risk to crop harvest and pasture from October-January due to reported groups of mature and immature desert locusts, and the expected hatching of first-generation locusts in Red Sea state in early October, along with expected invading swarms from neighboring countries. Desert locust attacks at the crop milking phase will likely influence the harvest and impact poor household access to local production from February to May 2021.
- Improved availability of pasture and water for livestock following the above-average rainfall will improve animal body conditions and household milk availability through the scenario period.
- Poor households are likely to begin migrating to urban areas (Port Sudan) in search of labor opportunities in December/January instead of February/March 2021 to meet the increased need for income due to the delayed harvest. Charcoal and firewood sales are likely to intensify from March to May 2021 as households seek to earn additional income for market purchases.
- From October-December 2020, the recently ended heavy rains and flooding are expected to increase human and livestock susceptibility to waterborne diseases due to a lack of healthcare and veterinary services, along with high water levels.

Most Likely Food Security Outcomes

Poor groups in Tokar, Agig, and Haya localities are likely to continue facing reduced food access between October and November due to the expected delay in harvest, high cereal prices, and low levels of income. These factors will continue to limit the ability of poor households to purchase the minimum required food basket while household and market food stocks remain at minimal levels extending the lean season. Poor households will increase their dependency on borrowing food and cash and support from better-off relatives to access food and income. Poor households will maintain low levels of income from agricultural labor opportunities. Family members are likely to migrate earlier than normal to urban centres for labor opportunities and work in traditional gold mining to send remittances for food purchases, reconstruction, and restoring assets. Although household food security will begin to improve with the start of the expected harvest in December, poor households will continue to face moderate livelihood protection deficits and remain in Crisis (IPC Phase 3).

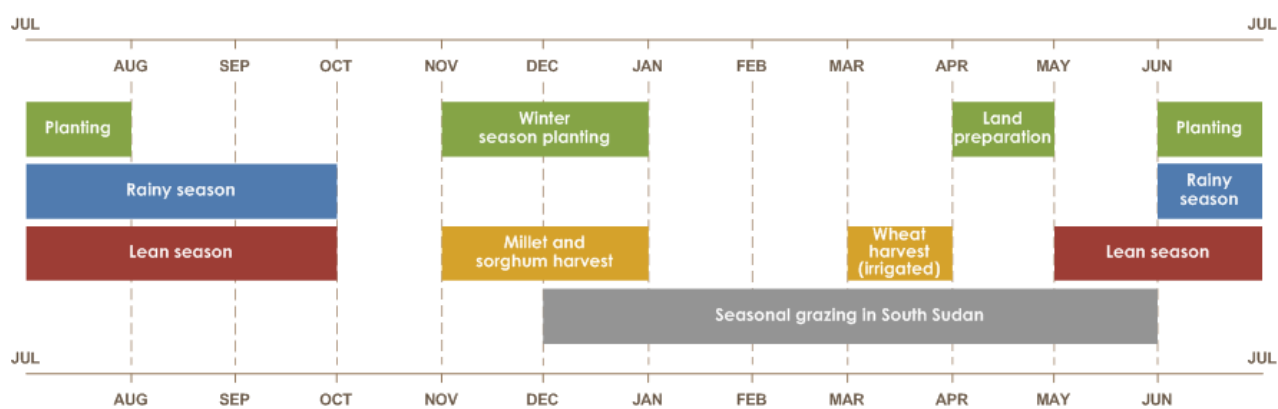
From February to March 2021, poor household food access is expected to improve during the post-harvest period driven by the availability of own household production, in-kind payments from agricultural labor, and an anticipated decrease in market cereal prices. However, household food insecurity will start to deteriorate in April and May with the beginning of the lean season. In April, poor households will increase their dependency on market purchases as household food stocks begin to reduce typically, and staple food prices increase seasonally. Poor groups will seek to expand income by migrating to urban centers and gold mining areas for labor opportunities, collecting and selling forest products, and relying on remittances. However, given the expected high needs for income to purchase food from markets and pay for reconstruction from the flood damage, poor groups in the area will continue to face increased food consumption and livelihood protections deficits, driving an increase in the number of people facing Crisis (IPC Phase 3) outcomes between February and May 2021.

Events that Might Change the Outlook

Possible events over the next eight months that could change the most-likely scenario.

Area	Event	Impact on food security outcomes
Tokar and Agig localities of the Red Sea state affected by flooding	An outbreak of tribal clashes and civil unrest before the harvest	An outbreak of tribal clashes or civil unrest could disrupt the harvest season, reduce labor opportunities, and disrupt access to markets. This could result in further displacement and a deterioration in food security outcomes from Crisis (IPC phase3) to Emergency (IPC Phase 4).
Tokar and Agig localities of the Red Sea state affected by flooding	Desert Locust attack	If the desert locusts invade during the crop milking stage and remain in the area through December 2020, there will likely be significant damage to the sorghum and sesame crops, and production will be below average. Below-average food and income from agricultural labor and crop sales will negatively impact household food access, leading to a deterioration in household food security outcomes from Crisis (IPC Phase 3) to Emergency (IPC Phase 4) from February through May 2021.

SEASONAL CALENDAR FOR A TYPICAL YEAR

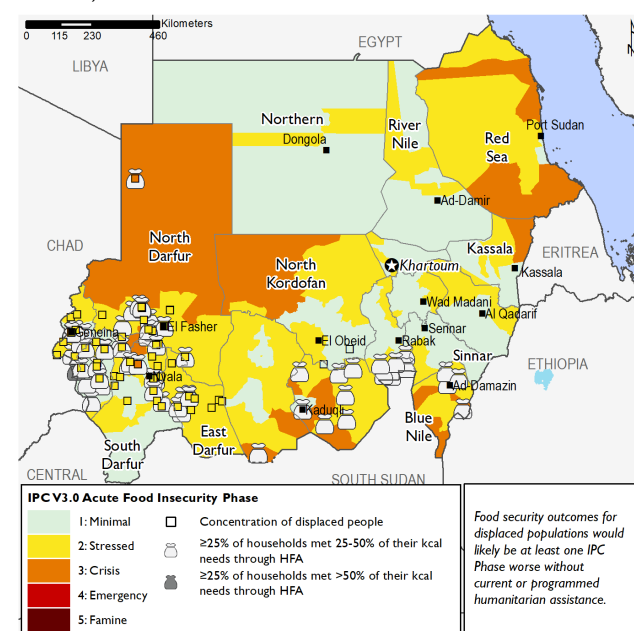


Source: FEWS NET

MOST LIKELY FOOD SECURITY OUTCOMES AND AREAS RECEIVING SIGNIFICANT LEVELS OF HUMANITARIAN ASSISTANCE

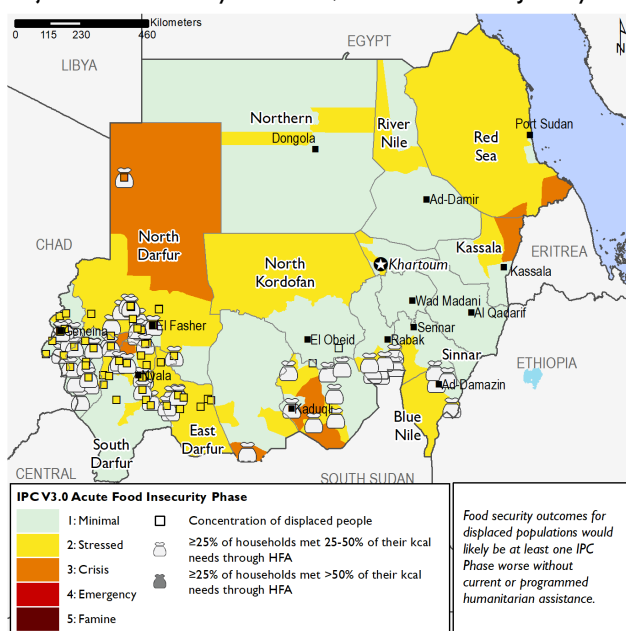
Each of these maps adheres to IPC v3.0 humanitarian assistance mapping protocols and flags where significant levels of humanitarian assistance are being/are expected to be provided. ☐ indicates that at least 25 percent of households receive on average 25–50 percent of caloric needs from humanitarian food assistance (HFA). ☐ indicates that at least 25 percent of households receive on average over 50 percent of caloric needs through HFA. This mapping protocol differs from the (!) protocol used in the maps at the top of the report. The use of (!) indicates areas that would likely be at least one phase worse in the absence of current or programmed humanitarian assistance.

Current, October 2020



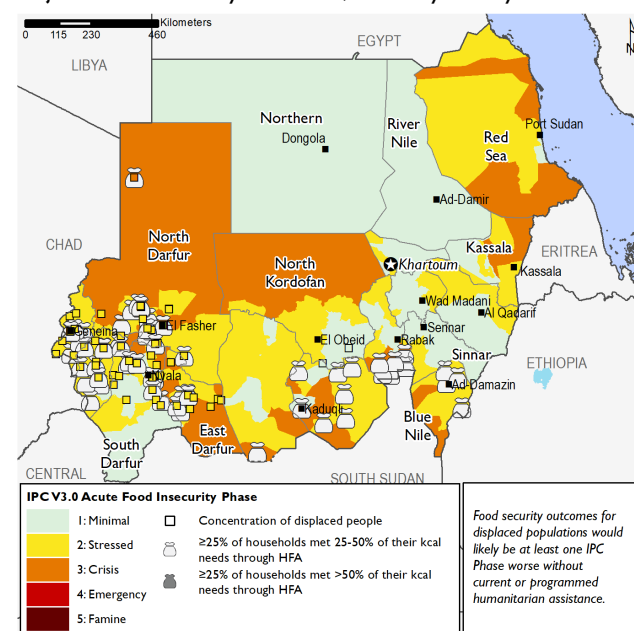
Source: FEWS NET

Projected food security outcomes, October 2020 to January 2021



Source: FEWS NET

Projected food security outcomes, February to May 2021



Source: FEWS NET

FEWS NET classification is IPC-compatible. IPC-compatible analysis follows key IPC protocols but does not necessarily reflect the consensus of national food security partners.

ABOUT SCENARIO DEVELOPMENT

To project food security outcomes, FEWS NET develops a set of assumptions about likely events, their effects, and the probable responses of various actors. FEWS NET analyzes these assumptions in the context of current conditions and local livelihoods to arrive at a most likely scenario for the coming eight months. [Learn more here.](#)

